



Pope Leo uses his first Easter Mass to call for peace



ALESSANDRA TARANTINO/AP

Pope Leo XIV arrives to preside over Easter Mass on Sunday in St. Peter’s Square at the Vatican. Celebrating Easter for the first time since he was elected pontiff last May, the Chicago native delivered a commanding message of peace to a world at war: “Let those who have weapons lay them down!” the first American pope declared. **Story, A9**

Vance heads to Hungary as MAGA ally Orban trails in polls

BY CATHERINE BELTON

When Vice President JD Vance heads to Budapest this week, his support for Hungary’s embattled prime minister, Viktor Orban, will represent a last-ditch bid to rescue the pro-Kremlin Hungarian who has forged ties to the top of the MAGA movement but is trailing in the polls ahead of a national election on April 12.

Questions are mounting about Vance’s visit, with polls indicating that Orban is falling increasingly behind his center-right rival Peter Magyar, who is challenging Orban over alleged corruption and Hungary’s flagging economy, in the toughest election Orban has faced since reclaiming the premiership

Visit is last-minute effort to save prime minister backed by Trump, Putin

16 years ago.

Orban’s campaign has been racked by reports that his government colludes with Moscow, and tension has risen over government efforts to crack down on his political opponents. A report by Russian foreign intelligence showed that Moscow was so worried about Orban’s standing that it considered staging an assassination attempt on Orban to try to boost his sagging popularity.

Orban reportedly wanted a visit by President Donald Trump, but Trump is focused on the Iran war and often doesn’t campaign for candidates at serious risk of losing.

“The U.S. Embassy certainly knows the polls and that Viktor is not on the winning track,” said Andras Racz, a senior fellow at the German Council on Foreign Relations’ Center for Security and Defense. “Betting on a loser — that sounds weird.”

Daniel Fried, a former U.S. ambassador to Poland and former assistant secretary of state for Europe, said Vance’s visit showed the White House putting unusual priority on a foreign election.

“The immediate rejoinder will

be: We’re at war with Iran. It seems to be going either not well or escalating — and this is how you spend your time,” Fried said. “Orban has made it a hallmark of his political culture to say we resist foreign interference, in particular from Brussels, and yet now he’s inviting foreign interference. ... I’m not sure it will work, and ... it smacks of desperation.”

A spokesperson for Vance played down the electoral dimension to the trip and said the vice president was looking forward to visiting Hungary “a close U.S. ally, to build on the progress President Trump and Prime Minister Orban have made on many key issues, including energy, technology, and

SEE HUNGARY ON A12

Airman rescued after fighter jet was shot down

CIA DECEPTION CAMPAIGN SET UP MISSION

Crewman hid in mountain crevice as Iranians neared

BY ALEX HORTON, TARA COPP, ELLEN NAKASHIMA AND DAN LAMOTHE

The U.S. military and CIA coordinated on a high-stakes mission that safely rescued the missing crew member of a fighter jet that was shot down over Iran, bringing to a close a dramatic and politically perilous moment in the war.

“WE GOT HIM!” President Donald Trump said in a post Sunday at 12:08 a.m. on Truth Social, describing the operation as one of the most “daring” search-and-rescue operations in U.S. history. All those involved in the rescue made it safely home. Trump, who is expected to discuss the operation in a Monday news conference, described the airman

in a later post as a colonel who was “seriously wounded.”

The multiday operation gave Trump and the United States a win to celebrate after more than five weeks of war with Iran and avoided what could have been a military and political catastrophe. The U.S. military has piled up tactical successes in the conflict, without clarity about how the president, who campaigned on starting no new wars, will extricate the nation from a conflict that has killed 13 U.S. troops, wounded hundreds of others, and upended global markets.

The airman — a weapons system officer of the two-seater fighter aircraft — was hidden in a mountain crevice and missing for about two days as Iranian forces and militiamen drew near,

SEE CREW ON A11

Trump threatens Iran with ‘Hell’ over Hormuz

Profane Easter message includes warning that U.S. will strike Tuesday

BY HANNAH KNOWLES, MARIANA ALFARO AND ALEX HORTON

President Donald Trump escalated his threats to target Iran’s infrastructure if it does not open up the Strait of Hormuz, warning the country will be “living in Hell” in an expletive-filled message on social media Sunday. He later suggested that the United States could target “every power plant” in the country — an attack that experts warned could amount to war crimes.

“Tuesday will be Power Plant Day, and Bridge Day, all wrapped up in one, in Iran,” Trump wrote on Truth Social, his social media platform. “There will be nothing like it!!! Open the Fuckin’ Strait, you crazy bastards, or you’ll be living in Hell — JUST WATCH! Praise be to Allah.”

The profane threat, which landed Easter morning a few hours after Pope Leo XIV issued a call for nations to choose peace, underscores tensions as there is little sign Tehran and Washington are close to striking a deal to open the vital shipping route that Iran has effectively closed since the attacks began about five weeks ago. Gas prices have risen sharply as Iran limits the flow of oil through the Strait of Hormuz, ramping up the political pressure

SEE IRAN ON A11

Trump’s war with CNN is entering a new phase

A pending sale to an ally of the president unsettles the network’s journalists

BY SCOTT NOVER AND LIAM SCOTT

Amid a public bidding war for Warner Bros. Discovery, President Donald Trump in December addressed a key asset of its media empire: CNN.

“I think the people that have run CNN for the last long period of time are a disgrace,” he said. “I think it’s imperative that CNN be sold.”

For more than a decade, Trump has railed against the cable network, making it a constant target in his attacks on mainstream news outlets that he argues are out to get him. He often calls it “Fake News CNN.”

And in the weeks since Paramount Skydance prevailed over Netflix to buy the conglomerate — placing CNN under the oversight of Paramount executive David Ellison, the son of Oracle

founder and Trump ally Larry Ellison, whose wealth backed the bid — Trump’s criticism has not waned.

Two weeks after Paramount won its bid, the White House issued a press release arguing that CNN was “lying” about its coverage on the war with Iran in an effort to undermine the success of the administration’s military operation. That same day, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth lambasted a CNN article on how the administration failed to anticipate the war’s impact on the Strait of Hormuz, calling it “fake news” in a press briefing.

“The sooner David Ellison takes over that network, the better,” Hegseth said.

The barrage from the Trump White House has taken on new meaning as Ellison’s ownership looms, raising the stakes and fueling anxiety among the network’s journalists. The younger Ellison has promised to respect the cable network’s editorial independence, but its employees worry about political interference and large cuts to personnel, since it would share a corporate

SEE CNN ON A7

For UCLA women, first title is a runaway



MARK J. REBILAS/IMAGI IMAGES

UCLA celebrates its first NCAA women’s basketball title, earned with a 79-51 rout of South Carolina in a final in Phoenix between the pair of No. 1 seeds. The win capped a dominant Final Four run for the Bruins, who didn’t trail all weekend. **Sports, C1**

Alzheimer’s and autism might have a connection

BY ARIANA EUNJUNG CHA

Joseph Buxbaum was initially unconvinced. When early hints of a connection between autism and Alzheimer’s began to appear in the medical literature a few years ago, they struck him as implausible — one a condition of early brain development, the other driving decline in old age.

But the signals kept accumulating, and over time, his skepticism gave way to a new line of inquiry that could transform scientists’ understanding of the two diseases.

“I came to this kicking and screaming. I didn’t want to believe it,” said Buxbaum, a professor of psychiatry, neuroscience and genetics/genomic sciences at the Icahn School of Medicine at Mount Sinai.

Autism has long been treated almost exclusively as a childhood condition, with little attention paid to how it evolves with age. First formally recognized as a

SEE ALZHEIMER’S ON A2

IN THE NEWS

New view of longevity A study shows that genetics and environment play roughly equal roles in how long we are expected to live. **A5**

Family dining The Popals have opened D.C.’s most consequential French and Mexican restaurants while retaining their Afghan culture — and staying out of the spotlight. **C8**

THE NATION
An unusually warm March across the United States, which included summerlike temperatures in the West, meant that trees and flowers were blooming ahead of schedule. **A4**

THE WORLD
Jerusalem’s Old City, usually bustling at this time of year, was quiet and eerily empty during Holy Week as authorities largely closed off the area to nonresidents during wartime. **A8**

THE ECONOMY
A new mobile app offers Americans “a direct line to the White House” and a rose-tinted view of the president. **A16**
Rising mortgage rates threaten to put a damper on home sales during what is traditionally the housing market’s busiest time of the year. **A16**

STYLE
The proposed Trump presidential library would be a giant tower of grift, Philip Kennicott writes. **B1**

SPORTS
The Nationals’ first home series of the season turns into a sweep at the hands of the defending champ Dodgers. **C1**

THE REGION
Three additional men were charged in the case of a 25-year-old D.C. woman who went missing in 2023. **C8**

HEALTH & SCIENCE
Lola Muñoz died at 13 of a rare brain cancer. Today, the siblings she never met carry her in their hearts. **D1**

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